

GLOSSARY

Terms in **bold italics** refer to other entries that appear in the glossary.

A

Accommodation

The process by which the eyes adjust to focus on nearby or distant objects.

Adenoids

Clusters of lymphoid **tissue** on each side of the back of the upper part of the throat.

Adipose tissue

Tissue made of specialized cells that store fatty (**lipid**) substances for energy, for protective "padding", and to provide heat insulation.

Allele

Form or version of a **gene**. For example, the gene for eye colour has blue and brown alleles.

Alveolus (pl. alveoli)

One of many tiny air sacs at the ends of the airways in the lungs. Gases diffuse in and out of blood through the alveolar walls.

Amino acid

One of about 20 kinds of building-block subunits of **protein**.

Antibody

A soluble **protein** that attaches to body invaders, such as **bacteria**, and helps to destroy them.

Aorta

The central and largest **artery** of the body. It arises from the left **ventricle** of the heart and supplies oxygenated blood to all other arteries except the pulmonary artery.

Aortic valve

A triple-cusped valve at the origin of the **aorta** that allows blood to leave the left **ventricle** of the heart but prevents backward flow.

Appendix

The wormlike, dead-ended structure attached to the large intestine. Its function, if it has one, is as yet unknown.

Aqueous humour

The fluid filling the front chamber of the eye, between the back of the **cornea** and front of the iris and **lens**.

Arteriole

A small terminal branch of an **artery** leading to even smaller **capillaries**, which link to the **veins**.

Artery

An elastic, muscular-walled tube that transports blood away from the heart to other body parts.

Atrium (pl. atria)

One of two thin-walled, upper chambers of the heart.

Autonomic nervous system (ANS)

The portion of the nervous system controlling unconscious functions such as heartbeat and breathing.

Axon

The long, fibre-like process of a **nerve** cell that conducts nerve impulses away from the cell body.

B

Bacterium (bacteria pl.)

A type of microorganism with one cell. Only a few of the many species of bacteria cause disease.

Base

In **nucleic acids** (**DNA**, **RNA**), a nitrogen-containing chemical unit or nitrogenous base (adenine, thymine, guanine, cytosine, uracil), the order of which carries genetic information.

Bile

A greenish-brown fluid secreted by the **liver** that is concentrated and stored in the **gallbladder**; released following food intake to help the digestion of fats.

Biliary system

The network of **bile** vessels formed by the ducts from the **liver** and the **gallbladder**, and the gallbladder itself.

Bone marrow

Fatty **tissue** within bone cavities that may be red or yellow. Red bone marrow produces **red blood cells**, **platelets**, and most **white blood cells**.

Brainstem

The lower part of the brain; houses the centres that control vital functions, such as breathing and the heartbeat.

Bronchus (pl. bronchi)

One of the larger air tubes in the lungs. Each lung has a main bronchus that branches into smaller and smaller airways.

C

Capillary

One of the numerous tiny blood vessels that link the smallest **arteries** and smallest **veins**.

Cardiac

Relating to the heart.

Cartilage

Type of connective **tissue** that is tough and resilient, and often flexible; forms some structural parts, such as the ear and nose, and lines bone ends inside joints.

Central nervous system (CNS)

The brain and spinal cord; receives and analyses sensory data, and initiates a response.

Cerebellum

A region of the brain located behind the **brainstem**. It is concerned with balance, posture, and the control of fine movement.

Cerebrospinal fluid

A watery fluid that bathes the brain and spinal cord.

Cerebrum

The largest part of the brain; made up of two cerebral hemispheres. It contains the **nerve** centres for thought, personality, the senses, and voluntary movement.

Chromosome

A threadlike structure, present in all nucleated body cells, that carries the genetic code for the formation of the body. Chromosomes coil into "X" shapes. A normal human body has 23 pairs of chromosomes.